Session 24

2025-10-05

1 - Rolling out

~12:00, 13 Nightal 1489 DR

1. The caravan breaks camp at noon after two days lying over in sight of **Barlon**'s tavern — tents struck wet, cold provisions stowed back on the carts, the beasts walked into their harnesses under a low Nightal cloud that has been spitting rain off and on since dawn. **Lord Zelan** crosses the yard for his lunch at the common room with his guards in a loose knot around him; they pass the convoy still jesting at its expense, with the tiny blue sage back inside his lamp. The hooded figure glimpsed upstairs has never come down in all this time — not for meat, not for water, not for a breath of fresh air.
2. The sisters **Arietta** and **Zelina** come with the convoy at the last of the mustering — the merchants made room for them on one of the carts when the tavern had refused them a bed. Arietta rides silent on the left side of the cart with her eyes on the road ahead and a blanket drawn to her chin; Zelina sits beside her and does the talking for them both — a quiet word for the driver who had taken them aboard, a nod for the party across the gap.
3. The convoy rolls out in its usual order: the three cultist carts at the head, the merchants' wagons through the middle, and two traveller carts at the tail — one of them **Darla** and **Gus**'s cart, Nuberroca's self-assigned post since the Trollclaws. The goliath takes his place at the near wheel without a word and stays there as the line stretches out onto the Trade Way, the tavern shrinking at his back.
4. Sinsong is away ahead of the caravan on his own trail; he had cut north off the main road days earlier after the **Company of the Boar**, intending to catch them before Waterdeep. The party does not expect him back on the main road before they reach the city themselves.

2 - Spilled cargo

~13:00, 15 Nightal 1489 DR

1. Two days' march after leaving Barlon's tavern, the convoy reaches **The Way Inn** — the Trade Way's hardened mid-stretch waypoint, a walled compound on the road's western side atop a grassy plateau. Three bridges lead up to gatehouses the size of small keeps, each armed with catapults; the inn stands stone and tile-roofed inside the walls under a lookout tower. The gates are shut and the compound closed to travellers while the renovation works are under way, so the convoy pulls off the road under the walls for a lunch halt — food out of the wagons, beasts unhitched to graze.
2. As one of the cultist carts rolls off the road into its halt position, a wheel bumps over a stone and jolts a crate loose from its lashings; the crate falls and cracks open on the ground, and the lid comes up long enough to show a spill of wrapped jewellery — items of worked gold padded in wool — before one of the cultists sweeps a cloak across the whole crate in a single motion and closes the spill back out of sight.
3. Mialee is across the gap first — she steps in from the nearest cart with her hands open at her hips, offering to help settle the lashings. The cultists wave her off hard: one plants a palm on the cloak atop the crate, the other puts a shoulder between her and it, and the refusal lands twice over, hands and voice — *we have it, we have it, step back*. Amidamaru closes from the other side a heartbeat later, kinder-voiced and open-handed, and meets the same wall — the two cultists shift to face him without lifting their weight from the crate, and the second *no* lands harder than the first.
4. Nuberroca drifts over a stride later on the same pretence — a loose strap on his own cart, he says, wanting a word on how the tie-downs had failed. Two more cultists step out from the next cart with their hands on their belts to make the count on their side even, and the words come at him before his hand gets within reach of the cloak — *they have it, they do not need help here*. The goliath holds the eye of the lead cultist driver for a long heartbeat before he gives ground.
5. With the party backed off the cultists tie the cloak down over the whole crate and lash the broken lid under it so no second glance can find the join. They stay posted around the cart through the rest of the halt, and when the convoy hitches up and rolls on by afternoon the lead driver's eyes do not leave the party's carts until the Way Inn's walls fall behind them.

3 - The long road north

1. The road climbs further north bordering the Misty Forest and, in the distance, they can glimpse the mountains near the Delimbiyr river. The path is clear and the weather bearable, and they advance without incident for several days.
2. Across those mornings the two sisters work the carts one by one — a greeting, a question, a drawn-out thread of family and road and where-are-you-from with everyone who answers them. By the fourth day they have been through every merchant, every guard, every traveller who will sit with them.
3. Nuberroca spends the leg riding ahead of the three cultist carts and dropping back behind them in turns, making a point of being where they can see him. He finds the cult drivers' eyes on him more than once. One of them — the lead cultist driver — holds the look longer than the others and does not break it.
4. At each night's camp the convoy rings up tight — merchant and traveller carts settling within a few paces of each other — and the party sits down to dice, bread and small beer with the merchants and the gnome Radecere, always looking for gambling; the sisters sit on the edge of these fires and listen.

4 - Into the pass

~13:40, 21 Nightal 1489 DR

1. The mountain pass of the Delimbiyr river is a treacherous one, a thin snaking gravel path with steep cliffs on one side and the roaring waters far below on the other. The convoy threads it single-file, the drivers setting the brakes a notch tighter and the guards closing up to the wheels.
2. On the thinner stretch of the pass the cart where Nuberroca is riding lurches into a lean; a rear wheel is loose on its axle and the whole cart tips toward the drop. Ahead on the pass, the lead cultist driver has turned in his seat to watch over his shoulder.
3. ***[EPIC]*** The goliath jumps with feline reflexes and sets his back under the frame of the wagon, holding it there with his own weight and the strength of his arms while **Anton**, who was walking in front of the cart, pulls the horses to help take the cart to safety.
4. The near guards rush to hold the axle with the barbarian, and between them they walk the cart back off the shoulder and down the pass to the wide cleared ground beyond, where the rest of the caravan has drawn up to wait out the single-file stretch.
5. With the cart secured, and Darla comforted by Gus, Amidamaru goes under the axle. The nails that pin the wheel into its socket are not there — not sheared, not broken, pulled clean out of the wood by someone who had the time to work them.
6. The tortle straightens from the wheel and tells the party his conclusion on the findings: the sabotage is deliberate, and the wagon had been in sight of the caravan all night.

5 - First blows

1. Kaelthar does not wait for the party to settle a plan. The cultists are a few places up the row and he reads the sabotage as their work — he summons his draconic wings and takes to the air across the caravan, flying over toward the cultist wagons.
2. Over the last cultist cart he pulls the wings and drops onto it with all his weight — the fall meant as a strike. The landing goes heavy and ugly, crashing across the frame rather than onto the bed, but the wood opens under him where he lands.
3. The cultists around the broken wagon have their blades and crossbows drawn before Kaelthar is back on his feet. They close in around the paladin, weapons up but held, shouting curses and foul names at the dragonborn.
4. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca goes in behind Kaelthar on foot. He crosses the gap between the carts in a rush, striking the first cultist guard who turns to meet him, and takes the man's head clean from his shoulders in a single stroke. The swing was meant to stop the man, not to end him — but a goliath's weight behind a halberd's blade was more than the cultist's slight frame could hold.
5. With the head on the stones the rest of the cultists forget their restraint at last. Blades come at Kaelthar and bolts fly at Nuberroca, their voices turning to steel.
6. Across the length of the convoy the caravan's guards raise crossbows at the goliath and the dragonborn. They have seen a fellow cart guard cut down without reason and they side with the innocent dead: the first shafts come in low, aimed for their legs rather than their chests, a wounding stop and not a kill. Two shafts find Nuberroca's thigh — and a blue glow comes up over the punctures, closing them shut almost as fast as they open.

6 – Fire in the cloud

1. Mialee sees the shafts flying and makes up her mind. She lays a thick fog across the three cultist carts — guards and party alike lose their lines of sight through the cloud — breaking the crossbowmen's aim and covering the beheaded body where it has fallen.
2. The caravan's shooters hold their fire. The crossbows stay ready across the length of the convoy, but no bolt flies into the cloud for fear of finding a friend in it.
3. ***[EPIC]*** Inside the fog Kaelthar draws breath and empties a cone of dragonfire across the two shapes that have closed on him. The fog flashes red from the inside for an instant, and the screaming comes a moment behind — the two of them go down burning on the stones and the cloud thins around them for a heartbeat before it closes back.
4. Amidamaru has not crossed into the fight. He holds ready at the fringe, watching for a chance to stop it before more people die. Eguzkilore holds beside him, out of Mialee's cloud: the caravan guards are the ones he has stood watches with across the trip, and he is not going to put himself on the wrong side of them by an unconfirmed suspicion.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Mialee closes on the nearest cultist through the fog while her ethereal hand searches the broken cart. The hand lifts the lid on a crate under the cover — chalices, religious icons, bags of small gems and jewellery stripped from statues, the cargo the party has been chasing since Greenest. Her blade finds the cultist in the same breath; he drops to the stones senseless but alive.
6. Through the cloud Mialee sees Kaelthar ringed by blades and crosses toward him. She closes on a cultist at the paladin's flank; they exchange blows in the fog, and she drops him senseless to the stones — but his blade had found her on the way down. The hit is enough to pull her focus from the cloud, and the fog thins and dissipates on the wind.

7 – The caravan turns

1. With the fog gone the caravan takes in the sight: three dead by the broken wagon — two still smouldering, one beheaded — and two more down unconscious nearby. From the bed of a wagon at the front the lead cultist driver throws his own version of the fight across the convoy — the party are robbers, they have come to rob the caravan, they have killed his companions — and the crossbowmen set the next shafts for killing shots as some of the caravan guards close to the carts with their swords out.
2. **Sulesdeg** and **Eldkin** come across at the two biggest shapes in the fray — the goliath and the dragonborn — with hands open for the grab rather than weapons drawn, iron cuffs ready at their belts. Eldkin reaches for Kaelthar beside the broken wagon; Sulesdeg closes on Nuberroca with his hands empty.
3. Sulesdeg closes the last step into Nuberroca's reach aiming for a grapple — and the goliath moves first. The polearm comes up in a single swing and drives through Sulesdeg's shoulder before his hands can close; the two of them hold a long heartbeat at the end of the shaft, and then Sulesdeg draws his massive sword and comes in on Nuberroca swinging, but the strokes pulled short of killing blows — a blue glow appears over Nuberroca's cuts, partially closing them. Eldkin and the rest of the caravan guards drop the grapple and pull swords with him.

8 – The leader's bolt

1. Meanwhile, across the broken wagon the cultist still on his feet fights Kaelthar; his blade comes over him in a single pass and the paladin goes down in the dirt beside the frame.
2. Mialee closes on the remaining cultist on Kaelthar and drops him with a swift move — her third strike of the day, soft enough to leave him breathing. The only cultist still on his feet is the lead cultist driver, firing his crossbow from the bed of a wagon at the head of the caravan.
3. Amidamaru breaks from his place at the fringe and lays a healing spell into Kaelthar's chest — the paladin's wounds close enough to keep the breath in him.
4. The leader's bolt finds Nuberroca while the goliath is fighting Sulesdeg; the shaft lands hard in his side, and he stays on his feet with the bleed opening on him.